

Degrees of Debt

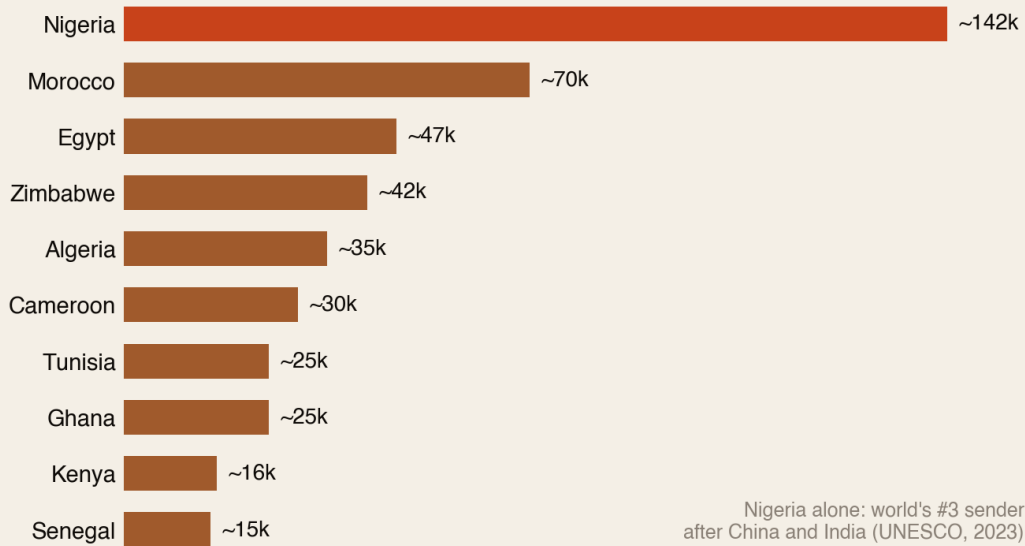
What Africans pay to study abroad, the debt that follows,
and the job that has to pay it all back

JULY 2026 · FACT-CHECKED · SOURCES CITED

142,000 Nigerians studying abroad (2023) — world's #3 sender (UNESCO)	\$35–60k all-in yearly cost of studying in the US or UK	~13% starting APR on loans available to African students — terms up to 20 years	86% Nigerian UK graduate-visa holders who found work — highest of any nation
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Studying abroad is the biggest financial bet most African families ever make: up to \$60,000 a year, funded by savings, sold land and 13%-interest loans — all resting on one conversion: **turning the degree into a job**. This report prices the bet honestly: who sends the most students, what it costs, the real study-to-work odds by destination, and the decade of debt that follows when the numbers are never said out loud.

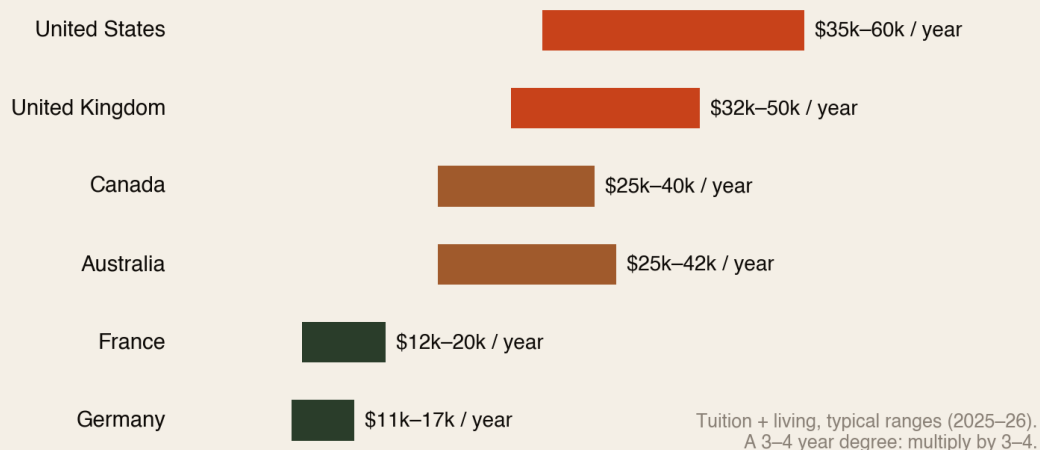
1. Half a Million Students: Who Sends the Most



Top 10 African senders (UNESCO UIS and national data, 2021–23; approximate — Nigeria's figure verified).

Nigeria's 142,000 makes it the third-largest sender on earth after China and India — up 98% in four years. And note the intensity: Zimbabwe, with 16 million people, sends almost as many students abroad as Egypt with 110 million. Africa overall has more than half a million students abroad.

2. What It Costs

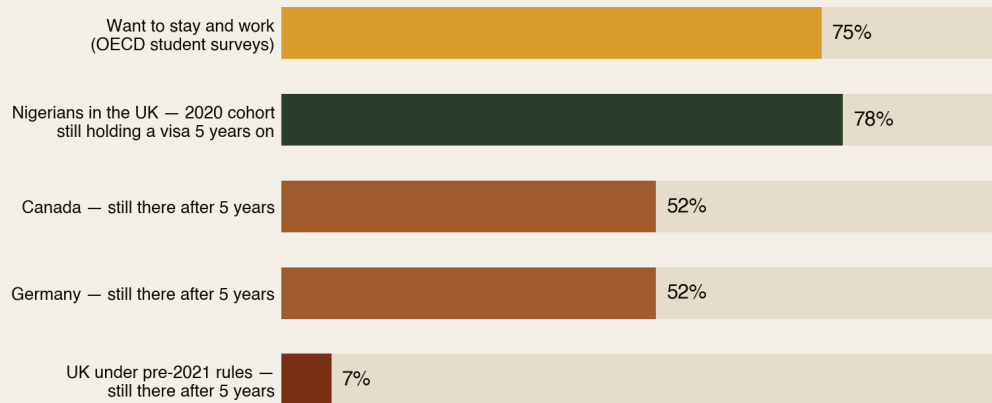


Typical all-in cost per year, 2025–26 (indicative). A 3–4 year degree multiplies these by 3–4.

One UK year (~\$40,000) is roughly 15 years of an average Nigerian salary. The money is real and it leaves: Nigerian families pushed over \$4 billion through official channels for foreign education in eight years — more per year than the federal education budget. It comes from savings, sold land, emptied pensions and family cooperatives. Notice also the arbitrage: France and Germany cost a third of the US and UK.

3. The Bet: Turning the Degree Into a Job

No country publishes a clean “came to study, got a job” number — stay rates and post-study visa data are the best proxies, and they vary wildly by destination:

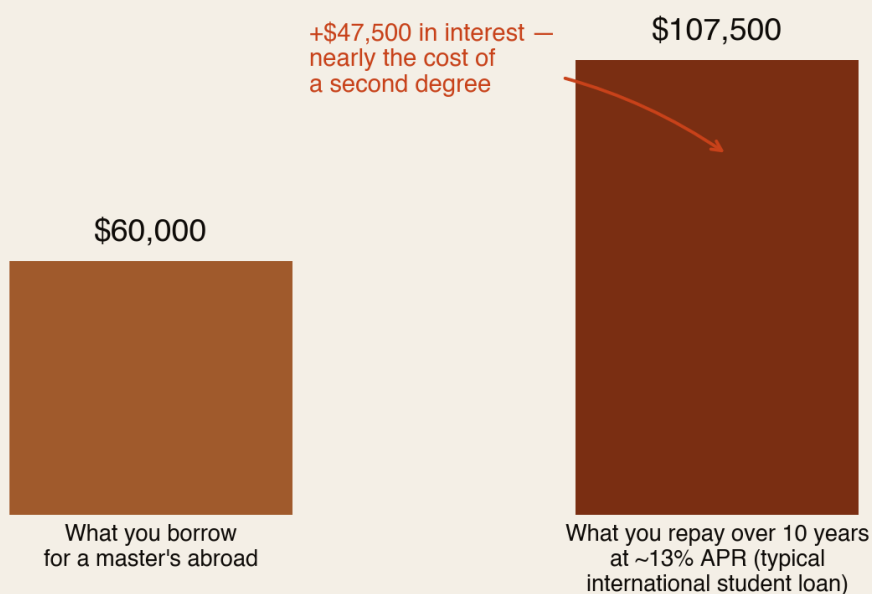


Wanting to stay vs actually staying (OECD; UK Home Office; Migration Observatory). Rules change fast.

The good news is real: 86% of Nigerians on the UK Graduate Route found work — the highest of the top five nationalities — and 78% of the 2020 Nigerian student cohort still held a UK visa five years on. But the door is policy, not right: the UK banned most students' dependants in 2024, Canada capped permits, and rules shift with every election. The same degree can be a launchpad one year and an expensive dead end three years later.

4. The Debt Years

African students mostly can't access domestic loan systems — no US federal loans, no UK student finance. The specialist international lenders that fill the gap start around 13% APR with 7–20 year terms; Nigeria and Ghana are among their top five origin countries worldwide.



Illustrative: \$60,000 at ~13% APR over 10 years ≈ \$107,500 repaid — ~\$900/month.

That \$900/month is manageable on a London or Toronto salary and impossible on most Lagos or Accra ones. And many students carry no formal loan at all — they carry sold family land and an unwritten repayment schedule that lasts just as long.

The loan is repayable in the destination currency and unpayable in the home one. That single fact quietly decides where a generation of African graduates lives.

5. When the Bet Fails

Graduate, no job, visa clock running. Post-study visas last 18 months to 3 years; every jobless month burns runway on a degree already paid for.

The rules change mid-degree. Students can graduate into a different country than the one they applied to.

Return home with foreign debt. A \$900/month repayment against a \$300/month home salary is an impossibility — so the graduate defaults, drains the family again, or re-emigrates. The debt makes the migration permanent even when the person wanted to return.

The current system converts what could be circular migration — study, work, return with skills and capital — into one-way pressure. The debt, not the dream, decides.

6. Making the Bet Smarter

Price the whole bet, not the tuition. Total cost = yearly all-in × years + interest + visa risk. If it only works with a destination-country job, say so before anyone sells land.

Choose by conversion odds, not just ranking. A German or Canadian degree with a 52% five-year stay rate can beat a famous name where the door is closing.

Use the cost arbitrage. France and Germany at a third of Anglo prices — the difference can eliminate the loan entirely.

Scholarship-first, loan-last. Every scholarship dollar is one that never compounds against you at 13%.

Read the loan like a lawyer. Variable vs fixed, grace period, penalties — and what happens if you go home.

If the family is the bank, write it down. Who paid what, what's expected back, and when.

Study abroad can still be the best investment an African family ever makes — if it's made like an investment, with the job, the visa maths and the exit plan priced in from day one.

7. How We Checked

Verified: Nigeria's 142,000 students abroad and world-#3 rank (UNESCO 2023, via Businessday); 86% of Nigerian Graduate Route holders in work and Nigeria's #2 share of UK graduate visas (UK Home Office); 78% five-year visa retention for the 2020 Nigerian cohort (Migration Observatory, Oxford); OECD five-year stay rates (Canada/Germany ~52%, pre-2021 UK ~7%); loan terms from ~13% APR, 7–20 year tenors (Prodigy Finance, MPOWER); Nigeria's \$4bn+ official foreign-education outflows over eight years (Guardian Nigeria / CBN). **Estimates (indicative):** top-10 sender figures other than Nigeria (UNESCO UIS, vintages 2021–23); per-destination cost ranges; the \$60k/13%/10-year loan illustration (our arithmetic on published terms). **Honest gap:** no country publishes “came to study and got a job” as one statistic — stay rates and post-study employment are the best proxies, labelled as such.